

Cut off all - לך לך מארצך וממולדתך ומבית אביך אל הארץ אשר אנאך (12:1) Hashem instructs Avram. פרשת לך לך (12:4) later it says. A few פסוקים later it says (12:4) וילך אברהם באשר דבר אליו ה' וילך אתו לוט ואברהם בן חמש שנים ושבעים שנה בצאתו מחרן. This pasuk requires tremendous elucidation, it is far more complicated than it appears on the surface. The אזנים לתורה, the Lutzker Rav, R' Zalman Sorotzkin [I've quoted him many times in the past, it's one of my favorite ספרים on the Torah, the אזנים לתורה, everyone should have a set] asks a series of penetrating and pointed questions which makes you think "How come I didn't think of that?" ה' דבר אליו ה' - The first question he asks is what's the פסוק telling you? Is there any other reason that Avram would have gone? Why does the pasuk need to explicitly say ה' דבר אליו ה' באשר דבר אליו ה' - Lot went along with him. But didn't Hashem just say he should leave his whole family behind? הקדוש ברוך הוא commanded Avram in the first pasuk ומבית אביך. Lot is from בית אביך. How did Avram bring Lot along with him? He asks a third question: וילך אברהם באשר דבר אליו ה' - the pasuk gives us his age. Why is the pasuk telling us his age now? What difference does that make? Also, if you would have left his age out, it would read like this: וילך אברהם באשר דבר אליו ה' וילך אתו לוט בצאתו מחרן. This recitation of Avram's age breaks up the narrative of Avram's leaving. What purpose is served by giving us his age in the middle of this pasuk?

We're going to say in the next pasuk that when Avram left, ואת הנפש אשר עשו בחרן - he took along with him all of the people he was מגייר. So certainly he would say his nephew is a כל שכן and would certainly be included. So that is why Lot is coming along. Avram had to bring Lot along, because he also brought along all the other נפשות. However, the pasuk reveals to us in a very subtle fashion Lot's ulterior motive. What was Avram's motive? To do the השם, דבר השם, as the pasuk says ה' דבר אליו ה' באשר דבר אליו ה'. What was Lot's motive? וילך אתו לוט. There are two words in the Torah that in English both mean "with him": וְעִמּוֹ and אִתּוֹ. In English, they mean the same thing, but אִתּוֹ means to go with him for your own purposes and וְעִמּוֹ means עמו. In English, they mean the same thing, but אִתּוֹ means to go with him for your own purposes and וְעִמּוֹ means עמו. Lot was going אִתּוֹ. It was a superficial connection and not the same thing as וְעִמּוֹ. Therefore, he went for his own purposes and not for the מחשבה of Avram. What was Lot's purpose? Why did Lot want to come along with Avram? The answer is, וילך אברהם באשר דבר אליו ה' - Avram is 75 years old. As we say in the lingo, he's no spring chicken, להבדיל. He's not a young man. Which fool would leave his uncle? Remember something, יצחק is not around yet. Right now, aside from Sarah, who is not a יורש, he is his closest living relative. He's Avram's יורש. Avram was a rich man. There's all the reason in the world to stick with him. If Avram is going someplace, he's taking his wealth with him, and therefore Lot was coming along. Lot's actual purpose was not because of his wanting to do what Avram does. It was a different כוונה completely, and that was to do what was good for him.

In ספר דברים we have the famous pasuk (28:9) וְהָלַכְתָּ בְּדַרְכֵי ה' - we have to go in the ways of ה' הקדוש ברוך הוא. We understand that that we do everything that Hashem does because we cannot really understand Hashem, but we're following his ways. חסד, רחום, חנון. This pasuk started from the beginning of our creation of ישראל, כלל, אברהם אבינו, the first of the אבות, tells you והלכת בדרכיו means literally, אברהם went in Hashem's way because that's what Hashem told him to do. A literal translation of the words that we've always learned for these years.

וְהָלַכְתָּ בְּדַרְכֵי ה' means you follow in Hashem's ways because that is the רצון השם. We follow everything that Hashem tells us because we want to do רצון השם. If we can get up to that מדרגה, which אברהם אבינו was, and we can aspire to that greatness, we will not have ulterior motives.

We all do things for our own ulterior motives. We always identify with אברהם and look down at לוט, saying that he was self-seeking. Aren't we all like that to some degree? Let us work on ourselves to aspire to the level of אברהם אבינו and to be better people and to serve בלב שלם הוא ברוך ה'.

